

THROUGH THE AGES

Religion

Most world religions are based on a patriarchal view of society that marginalizes the role of women. However, religious communities of women are still important across many faiths, and in some, females take a leading part as priests, pastors, ministers, and rabbis.



▲ Literate nuns

This fresco shows the Poor Clares, a Franciscan order founded in 13th century by Clare of Assisi, reading their missals. At this time, convents were one of the only places where women could be educated.

FROM THE VESTAL VIRGINS of the Roman Republic (see pp. 32–33) to priestesses in the Ryukyu Islands in Japan, women often served in significant ways in many ancient religions. In contemporary religions such as Hinduism, there is a long tradition of female priests, sages, and gurus. However, monotheistic religions have historically discouraged or prevented women from joining the priesthood. Judaism's first female rabbi, Regina Jonas, was only ordained in 1935, and most branches of Christianity, such as the Catholic and Orthodox churches, still do not allow women to join the priesthood.

Protestant churches differ. Quakers have ordained women since the faith's founding in the mid-17th century, and by the later 20th

century there were female priests in many other denominations including Anglican, Baptist, Methodist, and Lutheran. However, the most prominent role that women play in Christianity, and in Buddhism, too, is as nuns. Although there are wide variations between (and within) religions, most nuns live in a community, often enclosed, and abide by vows of poverty, obedience, and chastity.

Early nuns

Ordained nuns, known as *bhikkhuni*, have existed since Buddhism began in the 5th century BCE. The Buddha himself is said to have ordained the first *bhikkhuni*—his aunt and foster-mother Mahapajapati Gotami. Within Buddhism, women may join the *sangha* (monastic community). However, in some branches of Buddhism, nuns have to take more vows than monks to make them subordinate to male authority, as well as to increase the difficulty of being fully ordained.

“Taking **this road** ... we gain ... **treasures** ... no wonder if ... [the] **cost** seems ... **high**.”

SPANISH NUN ST. TERESA OF AVILA, *WAY OF PERFECTION*, 1577